St Ferghal and the Globalisation of the Middle Ages

In 1994, in the small village of Vrhpolje in western Slovenia, only a dozen miles from the Italian border, there was a rather unusual public event, attended even by a high-ranking national politician. On a rock just outside the village, the villagers erected a monument, remembering a battle that took place exactly 1,600 years earlier between the Roman (Byzantine) Emperor Theodosius and the western usurper Eugenius. Although probably unknown to the reader, the battle was of considerable significance for European history, and the encounter is regarded as an important milestone in late Antiquity.[3]

The high profile of the celebration shows how even remote historical events are sometimes used by people in so-called Eastern Europe to claim the early participation of their lands (not even of their people in this case, as the Slavs would have not entered modern-day Slovenia until at least the sixth century!) in the development of the idea of Europe. One may find such attempts rather desperate, especially if they involve a 1,600-year-old battle. But something else is also striking: how is it possible that villagers living in a place less than two hours' drive away from Venice need so much to prove that they really belong to Europe? And what happened on the other side of the divide, in so-called Western Europe, to make territory only a few kilometres away seem so distant, so culturally different, that it deserves a special name – Eastern Europe?

Although the example of, say, the Czech Republic and Germany is very similar, the situation is particularly shocking when one looks at Slovenia and Italy. Except in the years immediately after World War II, there was never really an Iron Curtain between Italy and Slovenia. In 2004, on EU Enlargement Day, Western media, hungry for iconic images of the Iron Curtain, repeatedly used photo-shots of the rather unthreatening fence between Italian Gorizia/Gorica and Slovenian Nova Gorica, a kind of mini-Berlin Wall, but this was much to the amusement of the locals who were used to commuting daily through a nearby border post even in Communist times. (The purpose of that particular fence was more to mark the borderline than to prevent trespassing, and the most controversial event